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Scholarships, Grants and Financial Aid: Apply Without Wasting Money

Find legitimate opportunities, prepare documents early and write a strong application

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Scholarship information is scattered and often surrounded by fraud. This pack explains where legitimate opportunities are announced, how to prepare a reusable document pack, how to write a personal statement that does not sound generic, and how to recognise fake portals.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Identify credible sources of scholarship and grant information.
- Prepare a reusable application document pack.
- Write a specific personal statement and request references properly.
- Recognise and avoid scholarship scams.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Where legitimate opportunities live

Reliable information comes from institutions, not from forwarded messages.

- University scholarship offices, faculty notice boards and official websites.
- Federal and state scholarship boards, and their verified portals.
- Corporate foundations and professional bodies in Nigeria.
- Embassy and international development programmes.
- Departmental and alumni awards, which are often under-applied for.
- Verify every opportunity on an official domain before submitting anything.

Prepare once, apply many times

Most applications ask for the same material. Build a pack.

- Academic transcripts or results, admission letter and student ID.
- A current CV of one page.
- A personal statement of 500 to 800 words that you can adapt.
- Two academic references with up-to-date contact details.
- Passport photographs in the required specification.
- Certificates and evidence of leadership or volunteering.

> **Legitimate schemes do not ask for payment**
> Application fees and 'processing charges' from unknown portals are a warning sign. Confirm with the institution before paying anything.

Write it specifically

Reviewers read many similar statements. Specificity is your advantage.

1. Open with a concrete moment that explains your direction, not a quotation.
2. State your course and the problem you want to work on.
3. Give evidence: results, projects, responsibilities, measurable outcomes.
4. Explain why this specific scheme, not any scholarship.
5. Describe what you will do afterwards in concrete terms.
6. Edit for length, clarity and one consistent tense.

How funding is actually decided

Scholarship panels are not looking for the most deserving person in the abstract; they are looking for evidence against stated criteria. Read the eligibility rules first and check whether you meet every one. A brilliant application to a fund you are not eligible for is wasted effort.

Most awards weigh three things: academic record, financial need, and the applicant's capacity to use the opportunity. Application quality matters because panels read hundreds of similar statements; specificity is what makes one memorable.

Timing decides more outcomes than talent. Applications have fixed windows, transcripts take weeks, and referees need notice. Work backwards from the deadline by at least six weeks.

The documents and the statement